Passive Voice

The passive voice is a grammatical construction that focuses on the recipient of an action rather than the doer. It is used when the subject of a sentence undergoes or receives the action, rather than performing it. In the passive voice, the subject of the sentence is typically the recipient of the action, while the doer or agent of the action may be mentioned or omitted.

Construction

To form the passive voice in French, you typically use the auxiliary verb "être" (to be) followed by the past participle of the main verb.

The past participle agrees in gender and number with the subject of the sentence.

One may also add a preposition to indicate the agent of the action, or simply omit it.

Français	English
Le film **est** tourné en Inde.	The film is being shot in India.
Ce roman **a été** écrit en 1927.	This novel was written in 1927.
Les remarques racistes ne **sont** pas **pardonnées** dans cet établissement.	Racist remarks are not forgiven in this establishment.
Beaucoup de fromage **est consommé** en France.	A lot of cheese is consumed in France.

Agent Introduction: Par Vs De

In the above examples, the agent is unknown. But if the agent is known, it is introduced by preposition - **par/de**

Passive Subject + Être (in required tense) + Past Participle of the main action + (Optional) par/de agent

Active voice: "Jean a construit la maison." (Jean built the house.)
Passive voice: "La maison a été construite par Jean." (The house was built by Jean.)

In this example, the active voice sentence has the subject "Jean" performing the action of building the house. In the passive voice sentence, the subject "la maison" (the house) receives the action, and "Jean" is mentioned as the agent using the preposition "par" (by).

Remember that the past participle must agree with the subject in gender and number. For example:

Active voice: "Les enfants ont mangé les gâteaux." (The children ate the cakes.)
Passive voice: "Les gâteaux ont été mangés par les enfants." (The cakes were eaten by the children.)

In the passive voice, "gâteaux" (cakes) is plural, so the past participle "mangés" also agrees in number and gender with the subject.

Let's take a look at some more examples!

Français	English
La plupart des tâches ménagères **sont faites** par des femmes.	Most of the household chores are done by women.
Cette pièce **est écrite** par les enfants.	This play is written by the children.
Les voleurs **sont poursuivis** par la police.	The thieves are chased by the police.
Ce film **n'est pas réalisé** par un professionnel.	This film is not directed by a professional.

However, the preposition **de** is commonly used after verbs expressing condition (state of being), emotion or when the agent plays a less active role.

Français	English
La ville romaine de Pompéi **est entourée** de murs.	The Roman city of Pompeii is surrounded by walls.
La plupart des politiciens **sont détestés** du public.	Most politicians are hated by the public.
Joshi Mastar **est estimé** de ses étudiants.	JM is respected by his students.
Votre décision **est très appréciée** de tout le monde.	Your decision is appreciated by everyone.

Note: "de" does not translate to "by" in every case.
E.g. La montagne est couverte de neige. - The mountain is covered with snow.

Important: To transform a sentence from active to passive voice, the verb should have a **direct object.** In French, verbs with indirect objects cannot be directly transformed into passive voice sentences. The passive voice in French is generally used with transitive verbs that have a direct object.

To clarify, a direct object is the noun or pronoun that directly receives the action of the verb, while an indirect object is the noun or pronoun that indicates to or for whom or what the action is performed.

Let's look at an example with an indirect object:

Active voice: "Le professeur donne des livres aux étudiants." (The teacher gives books to the students.)

In this sentence, "des livres" (books) is the direct object, and "aux étudiants" (to the students) is the indirect object. You cannot directly transform this sentence into a passive voice sentence because the indirect object does not become the subject in the passive voice. Instead, you would need to rephrase the sentence using a different construction.

One possible alternative construction is to use the **reflexive form**:

Passive-like construction: "Les étudiants se voient donner des livres par le professeur." (The students see books being given to them by the teacher.)

In this construction, the reflexive pronoun "se" is used, and the verb "voir" (see) is used to indicate the passive-like meaning.

So, while verbs with indirect objects cannot be transformed directly into passive voice sentences in French, there are alternative constructions that can convey a similar passive-like meaning.

Passive Voice with Different Tenses

Français	English
Présent : Ici, toutes les décisions **sont prises** par moi.	Here, all the decisions are taken by me.
Passé Composé : Cette décision **a été prise** par moi, pas le patron.	This decision was made by me, not the boss.
Imparfait : Avant la rébellion de Sylvia, toutes les décisions **étaient prises** par moi.	Before Sylvia's rebellion, all decisions were made by me.
Plus-que parfai t: La décision **avait été prise** par moi, donc j'étais responsable des conséquences.	The decision had been made by me, so I was responsible for the consequences.
Futur Simple : Comme toujours, la décision finale **sera prise** par moi.	As always, the final decision will be made by me.

Passé Composé

Active	Passive
Un avion **a percuté** les tours jumelles. A plane hit the twin towers.	Les tours jumelles **ont été percutées** par un avion. The twin towers got hit by a plane.
Les étudiants **ont taquiné** JM au sujet de son mariage. The students teased JM about his marriage.	JM **a été taquiné** au sujet de son mariage par les étudiants. JM was teased about his marriage by the students.
Ma cinquième copine **m'a largué**. My fifth girlfriend dumped me.	J'**ai été largué** par ma cinquième copine. I got dumped by my fifth girlfriend.
Nous **avons tourné** ce film en France. We shot this film in France.	Ce film **a été tourné** en France (par nous). This film was shot in France (by us).

Imparfait

Active	Passive
Nous **observions** les élèves pendant l'examen avec un œil vif. We were observing the students during the exam with a sharp eye.	Les élèves **étaient observés** par nous avec un œil vif pendant l'examen. The students were (being) observed by us during the exam with a sharp eye.
Quelqu'un **transportait** un corps au lac hier soir. Someone was carrying a body to the lake last night.	Un corps **était transporté** au lac hier soir (par qqn) A body was being carried to the lake last night.
Ils **fermaient** leur magasin quand je suis arrivé. They were closing their shop when I arrived	Leur magasin **était fermé** quand je suis arrivé. Their shop was being closed (by them) when I arrived.

Plus-que-Parfait

Active	Passive
Les enfants **avaient déjà mangé** le gâteau avant que je puisse le couper. The kids had already eaten the cake before I could cut it.	Le gâteau **avait déjà été mangé** par les enfants avant que je puisse le couper. The cake had already been eaten by the kids before I could cut it.
Je **n'avais pas regardé** tous ces dessins animés dans mon enfance. I hadn't watched all of these cartoons in my childhood.	Tous ces dessins animés **n'avaient pas été regardés** par moi dans mon enfance. All of these cartoons hadn't been watched by me in my childhood.
Les Raichands **avaient envoyé** Rohan à Londres en hiver The Raichands had sent Rohan to London in winter.	Rohan **avait été envoyé** à Londres par les Raichands en hiver. Rohan had been sent to London by the Raichands in winter.

Futur Simple

Active	Passive
JM **chantera** la chanson de Himesh si l'on ne l'écoute pas. JM will sing Himesh's song if we don't listen to him	La chanson de Himesh **sera chantée** par JM si l'on ne l'écoute pas. Himesh's song will be sung by JM if we don't listen to him.
Nous vous **féliciterons pour** votre succès. We will congratulate you on your success.	Vous **serez félicité pour** votre succès par nous. You will be congratulated on your success by us.
Les enfants **suivront** le guide. The kids will follow the guide.	Le guide **sera suivi** par les enfants. The guide will be followed by the kids.

Present Conditional

Active	Passive
Des exemples ordinaires **décevraient** JM. Ordinary examples would disappoint JM.	JM **serait déçu** des exemples ordinaires. JM would be disappointed by ordinary examples.
Si vous étiez l'ami de Donald, il vous **demanderait** de mieux écrire ses discours. If you were Donald's friend, he'd ask you to write his speeches better.	Si vous étiez l'ami de Donald, vous **seriez demandé** de mieux écrire ses discours (par lui) If you were Donald's friend, you'd be asked to write his speeches better.

Past Conditional Mood

Active	Passive
J'**aurais été** le gagnant si elle n'avait pas triché. I would have been the winner if she hadn't cheated	Le gagnant **aurait été** moi si elle n'avait pas triché. The winner would have been me if she hadn't cheated
Il **aurait acheté** la voiture à temps, s'il avait accepté l'offre immédiatement. He would have bought the car on time if he'd accepted the offer immediately.	La voiture **aurait été achetée** par lui s'il avait accepté l'offre immédiatement. The car would've been bought by him if he'd accepted the offer immediately.

Subjunctive Mood

The passive voice can go with certain expressions in the subjunctive mood.

Active	Passive
Il est nécessaire que tu **fasses** un effort. It's necessary that you make an effort.	Il est nécessaire qu'un effort **soit fait** par toi. It's necessary that an effort be made by you.
C'est terrible qu'un bus **ait renversé** Regina George. It's terrible that a bus hit Regina George	C'est terrible que Regina George **ait été renversée** par un bus.

	It's terrible that Regina George was hit by a bus.

Passive Pronominals

The passive voice can be sometimes replaced by the active voice in French by using the following passive pronominal verbs:

Note the Passive translation in English.

Français	English
se dire	is said
se faire	is done
se manger	is eaten
se boire	is drunk
se laisser	to be let
se prononcer	is pronounced
se traduire	is translated
se voir	is shown/shows
se lire	is read (as)
s'écrire	is written
s'entendre	is heard
s'entendre dire	is told
se vendre	is sold
s'acheter	is purchased
s'utiliser	is used
se passer	happens/goes

Français	English
Ça ne se dit pas !	You can not say that! (Literal translation: it is not said)
Ça se prononce avec un T.	That's pronounced with a T.

Ça s’écrit avec un S.	That’s written with an S.
Comment est-ce que ça se traduit ?	How is that translated?
Votre prénom, ça s'écrit comment ?	How is your first name written?
Ça ne se voit pas, mais il est très gêné.	You can't see it, but he's very embarrassed.
Ça ne se fait pas en France !	That’s not done in France!
Ça s’est bien passé, ton examen?	It went well, your exam?
Ça se comprend.	That’s understandable.

Using Generic Subject - On

We can also use “on” to replace the passive voice. Note that the English translations take the passive voice.

Français	English
On parle espagnol ici.	Spanish is spoken here.
On fabrique beaucoup de voitures ici.	Many cars are manufactured here.
On a pris la décision facilement.	The decision was taken easily.
On a vendu cette maison.	This house is sold.

To convert a sentence from passive to active voice, we can use on as the subject if the agent is unknown.

Je n'étais pas informé de ce changement. (passive voice, agent unknown)

On ne m’a pas informé de ce changement. (active voice)